

Driving with Arthritis in the UK

Can you drive with arthritis? UK guide covering DVLA notification rules, vehicle adaptations, Blue Badge eligibility, and tips for comfortable driving.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-15 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Many people with arthritis continue to drive safely with the right adaptations and awareness. However, it's important to understand your legal obligations and the help available to make driving more comfortable.

Do I Need to Tell the DVLA?

You must notify the DVLA if arthritis affects your ability to drive safely. This includes:

- Difficulty gripping or turning the steering wheel
- Reduced ability to operate pedals or gearstick
- Limited neck or spinal mobility affecting mirror checks
- Pain that could distract you while driving

Not all arthritis needs reporting — only if it affects your driving. If in doubt, contact the DVLA on 0300 790 6806 or your GP for guidance.

Vehicle Adaptations



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Various adaptations can make driving easier and safer:

- Steering wheel aids — spinner knobs, padded covers, or extended grips
 - Automatic transmission — eliminates clutch operation
 - Swivel seat cushions — make getting in and out easier
 - Key turners — larger handles for ignition keys (less relevant with push-start)
 - Pedal extensions or left-foot accelerator — for lower limb arthritis
 - Electric handbrake — reduces hand/wrist strain
 - Powered mirrors and steering — reduces physical effort
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Motability Scheme

If you receive the **Enhanced Rate Mobility Component of PIP**, you may be eligible for the Motability Scheme, which provides:

- A new car on a lease, including insurance, servicing, and breakdown cover
- Vehicle adaptations fitted at no extra cost in many cases
- Wheelchair-accessible vehicles if needed

Visit [motability.co.uk](https://www.motability.co.uk) for more information.

Blue Badge



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A Blue Badge allows you to park closer to your destination. You may be eligible if arthritis causes:

- Difficulty walking more than a short distance
- Severe difficulty using parking meters or pay-and-display machines due to hand arthritis
- A need for regular access to your vehicle for medical appointments

Apply through your local council website.

Tips for Comfortable Driving

- Plan breaks every 30-60 minutes on longer journeys
- Adjust your seat and mirrors before starting — use a lumbar support cushion
- Warm up your hands before driving on cold days
- Time medication to be effective during your driving period
- Consider driving during less congested times to reduce stress

Your safety and the safety of other road users is paramount. If you're unsure whether you should be driving, speak to your GP or request a driving assessment through your local mobility centre.

Q&A

Question: Do I Need to Tell the DVLA?

Short answer: You must notify the DVLA if arthritis affects your ability to drive safely. This includes: Difficulty gripping or turning the steering wheel Reduced ability to operate pedals or gearstick Limited neck or spinal mobility affecting mirror checks Pain that could distract you while driving Not all arthritis needs reporting — only if it affects your driving. If in doubt, contact the DVLA on 0300 790 6806 or your GP for guidance.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk